

But is business fool-proof in chat rooms that run amok with fake and multiple identities?

According to Verma from Innovision, "One loophole that is emerging on Ryze is fake identities. People put up fake information and pictures, and derive some kind of vicarious pleasure from the responses they get. Another issue is that several members—especially women—are getting a lot of unwanted, and at times, lewd messages from people who use a business Web site, such as Ryze, as a dating forum. That is causing them to take their pictures off their page, and not participate as much as they would have liked to."

Rao also talks of networking spam that floods his mailbox. So, how do Web sites maintain privacy and prevent spam?

Most Web sites have a strict privacy policy, which states that the user information will not be shared with any private party. Business networks, such as Ryze and Spoke, see to it that information isn't misused. Spoke, for example, checks a participating company's e-mail archives, contact lists, address books and calendars to create a detailed map of the organisation's internal relationships, as well as those emanating to other companies.

However, sceptics say that the day won't be far when Web site owners will be tempted to share that private information.

The Register (www.theregister.com) talks of a dangerous similarity between the privacy policy of Orkut and Microsoft, which allows the Web site to share, publish, or use a user's information as deemed by the company. Is this the harbinger of a new invasion of privacy, where our professional, as well as personal details, become publicly accessible?

Present and future

According to Tribe's Valerie Garing, "Social networking can capitalise on a quick and easy process to uncover new information from one's social circle, by leveraging personal and affinity networks to get things done in their daily lives. This is where we see the future of social networking—a key ingredient to a local, online classifieds service."

Das from Zytes affirms, "My value derivation from LinkedIn has crossed a point where I can even pay for this kind of service." Some cynics have termed social networking as a one more Internet bubble. How long the Web sites will sustain, is a question worth considering.

Patel is concerned that the growing popularity of these Web sites might result in them restricting replies and providing exclusive services to paid members. Krishnan perceives a threat of fragmentation—when there are too many functional or regional groups that crop up and people tend to gravitate towards the most subscribed. Rao is also worried about this kind of online balkanisation—the confrontation of technology and communication would be inevitable.

Another likely problem would be managing contacts. After registering, you will observe that you suddenly have more than 100 contacts—including your friends. How will you manage to keep in touch with so many? Does this mean that we need something more to help us sustain a network of this stature?

Thirty years ago, e-mail invaded our lives. Today, we chat across continents with ease, and write our own blogs. Now, the Internet goes a step further by helping us make use of our relationships for business growth. Social networking helps establish a global contact which would make relationship guru Dale Carnegie proud.

So, give your business a shot in the arm, and make sure you don't get left behind by your competitors. Start networking now! 

APARNA KRISHNAKUMAR

aparna_krishnakumar@thinkdigit.com

1 col AD



More sites to visit

www.zerodegrees.com

ZeroDegrees aims to bring people closer and emulate social behaviour. It plans to charge its users in the near future.

www.konnects.com

Founded in 2002, Konnects allows you to network industry-wise. Your profile here includes both, your skill sets and your expectations of future business partners.

www.entremate.com

Founded in 2003, EntreMate is the premier online resource that connects entrepreneurs to start up businesses. Like a dating Web site, EntreMate lets you post one or more profiles and search the database for others that share your business interests.

www.privinfo.com

A one-stop-shop that you can use as a navigator through various business networking Web sites. Privinfo classifies these as corporate, business contacts, job hunting, etc.